UNDER THE WEATHER

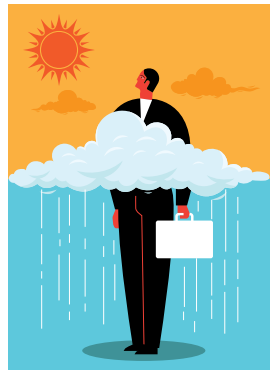


Illustration By: RAJ VERMA

Not for 122 years had March been as hot as it was this year. With an average maximum nationwide temperature of 33.1 degrees Celsius, it seemed obvious that climate change had stolen our spring. As all forecasts ask us to brace for many more heatwaves, it is, finally, in clouds that we find a silver lining. The India Meteorological Department estimates that rainfall in the country from June to September will be 'normal'. With Covid and the climate making everything unpredictable, we will suspect this 'normal', but maybe it's time to let the weather decide our travel itinerary.

ANI



Flights to Fancy

The introduction last month of the 17-passenger Dornier 288 (*pic above*) on Alliance Air's Dibrugarh-Pasighat route has been celebrated by residents of Arunachal Pradesh as another sign of the revival of civil aviation networks in the state. Another flight connecting Guwahati and the Tezu, the gateway to the Mishmi Hills, is already operational and another to Ziro is expected soon. The news also sparked an entertaining skirmish on Twitter over the German-designed Dornier's status as the first Indian-made commercial aircraft. It's not—as aviation buffs quickly established. That distinction goes to the British HS Avro 748 (*pic below*), first built by HAL for Indian Airlines in the 1960s.



WHAT WILL BE THE TOURIST HIGHLIGHT IN YOUR STATE THIS SUMMER?



"Adventure tourism is being given a big thrust. More than 30 sites are being developed—each will have facilities for camping adventure activities, nature trails, birdwatching, stargazing, boat rides and water sports. This includes lesser-known destinations like Kolli Hills and Jawaddhu Hills. The national kite surfing championship, the first of its kind, was held recently in Tuticorin. Snorkelling and scuba-diving are now being offered in Gulf of Mannar and Rameswaram. A state-of-the-art 3D mapping sound-and-light show at Arjuna's Penance in Mahabalipuram will be a new attraction this summer. With diverse beach-front activities and water sports, the Mudaliyarkuppam Island is also a summer highlight."

DR B. CHANDRA MOHAN, TOURISM SECRETARY, TAMIL NADU



"While our focus has been to develop tourist amenities and destinations for visits throughout the year, there are certain activities that are more thrilling at a particular time. For the summer season, a scuba diving amenity has been developed at Sailani Island in Omkareshwar. Destinations like Pachmarhi, and adjoining places like Churna and Tawa Dam, offer relief from the sweltering heat. For the monsoons, Madhya Pradesh offers 'Buffer Main Safar', a chance to go on safari in the buffer areas of tiger reserves, the core areas of which are closed during the monsoon months."

SHEO SHEKHAR SHUKLA, TOURISM SECRETARY, MADHYA PRADESH



"Our slogan is 'Come to Jammu and Kashmir, we will show you the world'. By introducing heritage walks, we are going to offer tourists an experience of local culture, handicrafts and history. We also hope to take tourists to temples, and even to cherry and apple orchards. Also, in the 75th year of our lependence, we are opening up 75 untapped destinations in Jammu and Kashmir to tourists. These include Gurez, Bangus Valley, Basoli and Bani. We'll be hosting festivals in all these places."

SARMAD HAFEEZ, TOURISM SECRETARY, JAMMU & KASHMIR



"The last two years have been a major challenge for tourism. Lately, we have seen several new tourism trends and, keeping them in mind, we have multiple plans. These range from creating more space and facilities at existing destinations like Mahabaleshwar, while also opening verdant and lesser-known spots like Jawhar. We are stressing on responsible and environment-friendly tourism now."

VALSA NAIR SINGH, TOURISM SECRETARY, MAHARASHTRA